information and phone number. This helped the FBI to match the man's driver's licence photo to CCTV footage from the Capitol. Another warrant issued to Google yielded the exact geolocation of the man's smartphone on 6 January, enabling agents to map his every movement from his entry point into the Senate chamber all the way to the office of Nancy Pelosi, the speaker of the House of Representatives.

Relying on licence plate footage, the FBI pinpointed the movements of a New York man from the moment he crossed the Henry Hudson Bridge at 6:06:08 on the morning of 6 January, on his way to the Capitol, until he crossed the George Washington Bridge at 23:59:22 that night, on his way back home. An image taken by a camera on Interstate 95 showed an oversized 'Make America Great Again' hat on the man's dashboard. The hat was matched to a Facebook selfie in which the man appeared wearing it. He further incriminated himself with several videos he posted to Snapchat from within the Capitol.

Another rioter sought to protect himself from detection by wearing a face mask on 6 January, avoiding live-streaming and using a mobile phone registered in his mother's name – but it availed him little. The FBI's algorithms managed to match video footage from 6 January 2021 to a photo from the man's 2017 passport application. They also matched a distinctive Knights of Columbus jacket he wore on 6 January to the jacket he wore on a different occasion, which was captured in a YouTube clip. The phone registered in his mother's name was geolocated to inside the Capitol, and a licence plate reader recorded his car near the Capitol on the morning of 6 January.[27]

Facial recognition algorithms and AI-searchable databases are now routinely used by police forces all over the world. They are deployed not only in cases of national emergencies or for reasons of state security, but for everyday policing tasks. In 2009, a criminal gang abducted three-year-old Gui Hao while he was playing outside his parents' shop in Sichuan province, China. The boy was then sold to a family in Guangdong province, about 1,500 kilometres away. In 2014, the leader of the child-trafficking gang was arrested, but it proved impossible to locate Gui Hao and other victims. 'The appearance of the children would have changed so much,' explained a police investigator, 'that even their parents would not have been able to recognise them'.